Introspecting Development[6]

Confusion about the real meaning of development did start only after the World Bank and the International Monetary Fund came into being i.e post-war. As experts were studying the development process of the developing world, they were also surveying the performance reports of the developed world. As the western world had been declared the developed countries having top twenty ranks on the HDI, social scientists started evaluating the conditons of life in these economies. Most of such studies concluded that life in the developed world is every thing but happy. Crime, corruption, burglaries, extortion, drug trafficking, flesh trade, rape, homicide, moral degradation, sexual perversion, etc.—all kinds of the so-called vices were thriving in the developed world. It means development had failed to deliver them happiness, peace of mind, a general well-being and a feeling of being in good state. Scholars started questioning the very efforts being made for development around the world. Most of them have suggested a re-defining of development which could deliver happiness to mankind.

Why development has not delivered happiness to the developed world? The answer to this question does not lie in any one objective fact but touches so many areas of human life. First, whenever economists from the outset talked about progress they meant overall happiness of human life.

Social scientists, somehow have been using terms such as progress, growth, development, well-being, welfare as synonyms of ***'happiness'***. Happiness is a normative concept as well as a state of mind. Therefore its idea might vary from one economy to the other.

Second, the period in which development was defined, it was considered that with the supply of some selected material resources human life can be improved. These resources were pin-pointed as, a better level of income, proper level of nutrition, healthcare facilities, proper levels of literacy and education, etc.

Happiness is a broader thing than development. The so-called 'development' for which the world has been striving hard for last many decades is capable of delivering material happiness to mankind. Happiness has its non-material side also. It means while the world has been trying to maximise its developmental prospects i.e. material happiness, it could not